

Why Our People Leave — And What We Can Do About It

Workforce Retention Briefing · Prepared for the HR Director · Internal Use

RETENTION RISK REVIEW

We looked closely at our workforce data to answer a simple question: when someone decides to leave, what was true about their job in the months before that decision? The patterns are consistent enough to act on. This brief lays out the three biggest warning signs, where in the business the problem is most concentrated, and two changes worth making this quarter.



WHAT ACTUALLY PREDICTS AN EXIT

01 Sustained overtime

This is the clearest signal in the data. Employees who are routinely working beyond standard hours leave at a noticeably higher rate than peers in the same role who aren't. Read together with the tenure pattern below, it looks less like a one-off busy season and more like ongoing workload strain that builds until someone decides to leave.

02 Thin long-term incentives

People with little or no equity stake in the company show up disproportionately among those who leave. Where someone has a real financial reason to stay for the long run, they tend to. Where they don't, the calculation tilts toward the next offer.

03 Day-to-day dissatisfaction

How someone rates their role, their manager relationship, and their immediate environment moves with attrition risk more than almost anything else we measured. Pay is part of the picture too — departing employees earned less, on average — but it trails behind these three factors rather than leading them. A raise on its own would not be expected to fix this.

WHERE THE RISK CONCENTRATES

Sales carries the heaviest load. Roughly one in five people in the department leave within the period we studied — well above the company average — with frontline sales roles driving most of that gap.

Customer-facing sales roles are the sharpest outlier. Within Sales, the quota-carrying, customer-facing roles lose people at close to double the departmental average — these positions combine high overtime exposure with the most variable, pressure-driven workload in the company.

Specialist technical staff are a quieter but costly risk. Skilled technical roles in Research & Development show the next-highest exit rate. These employees take the longest to replace and train, so every departure here carries an outsized cost relative to headcount.

New hires are the most fragile group. The first two years on the job carry meaningfully higher attrition risk than any later tenure band — we are most often losing people before their hiring and training costs have been recovered.

TWO MOVES WORTH MAKING THIS QUARTER

1. Put a ceiling on chronic overtime in the highest-risk roles. Start with frontline Sales and specialist R&D technical staff. Where overtime has become routine rather than occasional, rebalance workloads, add headcount, or offer compensated time off — and track work-life balance as an ongoing HR metric, not a one-time fix.

2. Close the early-tenure gap with equity and structured check-ins. Extend equity participation further down the tenure ladder, and put real 90-day, 6-month, and 1-year conversations in place so dissatisfaction surfaces — and can be addressed — well before someone starts looking elsewhere.

HOW TO USE THIS BRIEFING

- **Treat scores as a starting point for a conversation,** not a verdict — the right next step is a check-in with a manager, not an automated action.
- **Re-run this view quarterly.** Risk shifts as teams change, so a name on this list today may not belong there in three months, and vice versa.
- **Pair it with exit interview themes.** The patterns here explain who is likely to leave; exit conversations explain the texture of why, in their own words.

WHAT DID NOT TURN OUT TO MATTER MUCH

- **Distance from home and business travel frequency** showed only a weak relationship with who left — not the driver many assumed going in.
- **Education level and field of study** had little bearing on attrition once role and overtime were accounted for.
- **Gender and age** were not meaningful predictors on their own — the workload and engagement signals above explain far more of the picture.

Bottom line for leadership: attrition here is not random and not primarily a pay problem — it is concentrated by role, by tenure, and by workload, which means it is addressable with targeted action rather than a blanket policy change. These findings describe risk, not certainty, and reflect past behavior — they should be revisited as pay, management, or culture evolve. Above all, this analysis exists to help us support people earlier, not to single anyone out.